

1 TB notebook HDD

The 2.5-inch WD Scorpio Blue 1TB is now available, and ships for ₹10,650, excluding taxes <http://bit.ly/tZ3MaX>

Nokia to train Indian students

Nokia has tied up with Chennai-based Bharath University, to educate students about mobile technology <http://bit.ly/t283Kj>

A fancy tech buzzword with some serious potential or a quasi smartphone feature? We put NFC or Near Field Communications under the scanner and gauge its potential

NFC:

The possibilities

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Back in 2010, Google unveiled its flagship touchscreen smartphone with a twist. It had just dumped HTC after two successive years of Google-branded phones to partner with Samsung. The Nexus S was born and it had a curious feature called NFC. Though hardly a new technological breakthrough, the Nexus S helped

catapult NFC back into popular imagination. Since then, quite a few smartphones have featured NFC chips, but it's scarcely more than a bonus feature, because the ecosystem to implement and deploy NFC-based tasks and services doesn't exist. In some ways, NFC-enabled phones are a bit ahead of their time. However, a range of tech analysts and commentators are betting on 2012 being the year of NFC. The biggest early trend will be of mobile payments, according to a CNN report. Services such as Google Wallet, Visa Wallet and ISIS (mentioned later in the article) will kickstart the NFC party coupled with a new wave of smartphones that will hopefully help this promising technology go from strength to strength.

A BRIEF HISTORY

NFC is essentially a subset of RFID (Radio Frequency Identification), and is a wireless standard approved as

early as 2003. NFC's acceptance into everyday life was largely due to the combined efforts of Nokia, Philips and Sony, who founded the NFC Forum back in 2004. Unsuccessful trials of NFC took place between 2007 and 2008 with little support from vendors. Soon, NFC hit a roadblock and went into limbo.

The industry is now responding favourably to NFC deployments. The NFC Forum now has over 200 members – with Google joining as a prime member last year, and being committed towards charting NFC's roadmap. Japan and a few European countries have deployed NFC in a few scenarios, while the rest of the world, including India and the US, are still researching business models. So we have phones with this capability, but nowhere to use them just yet. However, much like we tried to do with our PCs for years, we are now future-proofing our phones!

